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A SHORT HISTORY OF BURMA TO 1948

The attitude towards the Rohingyas that the Myanmar establishment displays, and its hostile actions towards the Rohingyas, are informed by a narrative that the Rohingyas do not have a legitimate place in the state. Usually this is simply expressed in openly racist terms (often linked to anti-Muslim prejudices), but there are some attempts being made to justify these prejudices using scholarship. As we will see in this chapter, not only is such scholarship badly flawed but, of course, it is completely irrelevant in any case.

The establishment narrative ignores the inconvenient reality that the territory occupied by historical Burmese states does not correspond neatly to the territory of Myanmar today: the modern province of Rakhine was only ever part of the earlier Burmese states for relatively brief periods of time. It is therefore no surprise that it has an ethnic mix very different to that of the rest of the country, especially as few modern states represent a perfect match between ethnic groups and political boundaries.

The history of the region of Burma has seen a sequence of ethnic shifts, conquest, expansion and collapse that is quite typical of the history of most regions in the world. In the last millennium-and-a-half, there has tended to be a core state or core in the Irrawaddy Valley, which repeatedly expanded towards and contracted from the periphery of the modern-day territory of Myanmar; it should therefore should come as no surprise that by the mid-1990s around one-third of the population of Myanmar was made up of ethnic groups distinct from the Burman majority.[1] This naturally reflected the history of interaction with China to the north, India to the west, Thailand and Laos to the east and Indonesia and Malaysia to the south. In particular, the mountainous regions to the north and east of the central